

Australian biofouling management requirements for commercial vessels

The [Australian biofouling management requirements](#) for commercial vessels (ABFMR-CV) set out obligations for the management of biofouling for operators of commercial vessels. These obligations apply when operating vessels under biosecurity control within Australian territorial seas, in order to comply with the Biosecurity Act 2015.

Operators of all commercial vessels subject to biosecurity control must provide information relating to biofouling management through the mandatory pre-arrival report (PAR). This information is reported through the department's [Maritime and Aircraft Reporting System](#) (MARS). The department uses the information to target vessel interventions.

Our biosecurity officers may check this information during a vessel inspection. Documentary evidence must be available if we ask for it.

Commercial vessel operators who cannot demonstrate accepted biofouling management practices will be asked additional questions about how the vessel's biofouling has been managed. We may also conduct inspections of submerged hull and niche areas.

For information relating to non-commercial vessels such as yachts, see [biofouling for non-commercial vessels](#).

Proactive biofouling management options

Vessel operators can demonstrate proactive management of biofouling by implementing one of the three accepted proactive biofouling management options:

Option 1: Implement an effective biofouling management plan and record book

If you report that you have implemented an effective biofouling management plan and record book for the vessel, you must be able to provide us with:

- a biofouling management plan (BFMP).
- a biofouling record book (BFRB).

The biofouling management plan and biofouling record book must meet the minimum standards set out in ABFMR-CV to satisfy the requirements of option 1.

Biofouling management plan

An effective BFMP must be vessel specific and should be included in the vessel's operational documentation. The BFMP must have sufficient detail for the crew to implement the specified biofouling management activities.

Email biofouling@aff.gov.au to obtain a biofouling management plan example template.

Biofouling record book

The BFRB should contain a complete and up-to-date record of all biofouling management activities undertaken on the vessel and used in conjunction with the BFMP. It should be kept from the date the BFMP came into effect and retained for the life of the vessel. The BFRB may be electronic or in hard copy and available for inspection on request.

Option 2: Clean all biofouling within 30 days prior to arriving in Australian territory

If you report that the vessel has been cleaned of all biofouling within 30 days prior to arrival in Australian territorial seas, the following documents must be provided:

- a cleaning report
- supporting photographs and/or video.

The cleaning report and supporting evidence must meet the minimum standards set out in ABFMR-CV to satisfy the requirements of option 2.

Option 3: Alternative biofouling management method approved by the department

If you report that the vessel has an alternative biofouling management method, it must be approved by the department and you must provide:

- department-issued written approval, specific to the vessel and voyage
- any specified documents in the department issued approval.

Approval of the alternative biofouling management method must be obtained from the department prior to arrival to meet the requirements of option 3.

Obtaining approval

The department will consider applications for an alternative biofouling management method if the vessel operator can provide:

- a proposed alternative method that appropriately manages the biosecurity risk associated with the vessel's biofouling

- sufficient evidence to substantiate the proposal.

Applications for an alternative biofouling management method must include:

- a completed and signed application form
- the most recent in-water inspection and cleaning reports
- evidence to support your application.

The application must be submitted to biofouling@aff.gov.au no later than 30 days prior to arrival in Australian territorial seas. You can use the department's application form for approval of an alternative biofouling management method.

Application for an alternative biofouling management method form

If you have difficulty accessing these files, visit [web accessibility](#) for assistance.

The department may request further information to process the application.

Vessel operators that cannot demonstrate proactive biofouling management practices

A vessel operator that cannot demonstrate proactive biofouling management practices using one of the three accepted management options will be required to provide additional information in their pre-arrival report.

We will use these responses to make a preliminary assessment of the biosecurity risks associated with the biofouling management practices on the vessel. This will determine the actions taken by the department on arrival into Australia.

Australian biofouling management requirements

For more information on Australia's biofouling management requirements, see the [Biofouling resources](#) page.

- [Australian biofouling management requirements for commercial vessels \(PDF 797 KB\)](#)
- [Australian biofouling management requirements for commercial vessels \(DOCX 1.4 MB\)](#)

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Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/aircraft-vessels-military/vessels/marine-pest-biosecurity/biofouling/biofouling-commercial-vessels>